

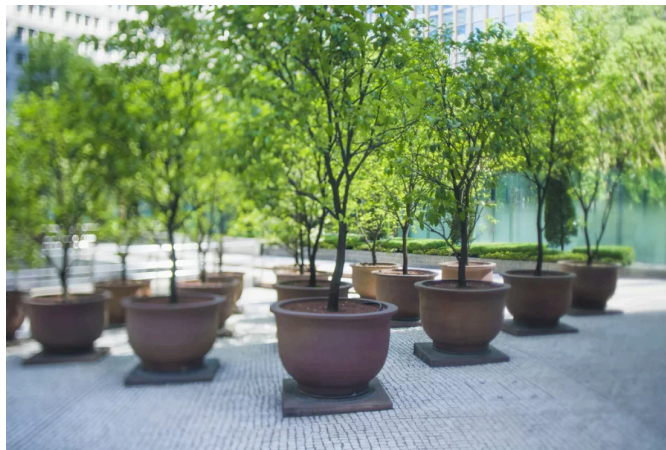
Session 12: The Hebrew Bible Is Like an Aspen Grove

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible can be likened to an aspen grove—it's a collection of texts that are distinctive yet share interconnected origin points and grow together as a united structure telling one cohesive narrative.
- Another way to describe hyperlinks is intertextuality, where a specific text only means what it means in light of the entirety of texts it is connected to. The meaning is found in the interconnection of the texts.

How the Hebrew Bible Is Like an Aspen Grove

Our common conception of the canon of the Hebrew Bible is similar to a collection of potted plants. Each book is a self-contained entity that was formed in basic isolation from the others, and there was a long process of pots/books being moved in or out of the garden until one day the gardener decided to put up a fence and lock the gate so that no more movement can take place.



The Spruce (2021) [Pinterest](#)

A view of the canon informed by both historical and textual data found within the Hebrew Bible is more similar to a grove of aspen trees. There is an oldest root system underground that branches out and grows new trees that are distinct above ground. But they are interconnected underground and share the same genetic code so that they grow symbiotically and mutually until they all reach maturity together.



J Zapell (2013) [Wikipedia](#)

Analogy adapted from Julius Steinberg and Timothy Stone (2015), “The Historical Formation of the Writings in Antiquity,” in *The Shape of the Writings*. Eisenbrauns. 5-11.

Reflection Question

The Hebrew Bible can be likened to both a quilt and to an aspen grove. Do either of these analogies strike you as particularly helpful? Why or why not?